● ARCHIVE EDITION 04

VOICE PACK ARCHIVE

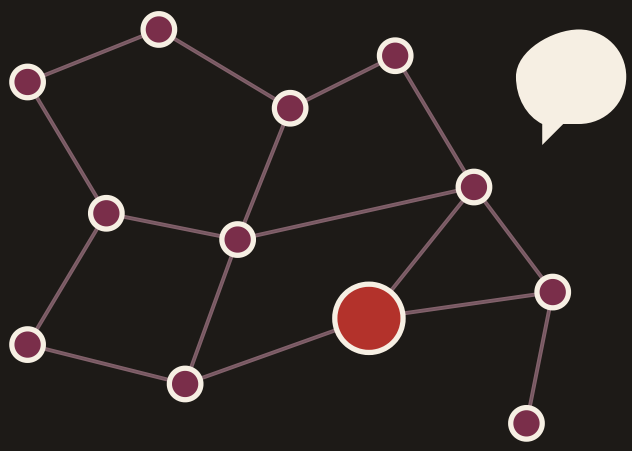
From Voice to Change

“How can young people change the systems affecting our health?”

When enough people describe the same experience, it stops being a personal story and becomes evidence. This edition is about noticing that shift, and what young people can do with it.

01 UNDERSTAND | 02 NAVIGATE | 03 ADVOCATE | 04 CONNECT | 05 AMPLIFY | 06 CHANGE

About 35 minutes to read For ages 14+



EDITION 04 · FROM VOICE TO CHANGE

FROM THE ARCHIVE

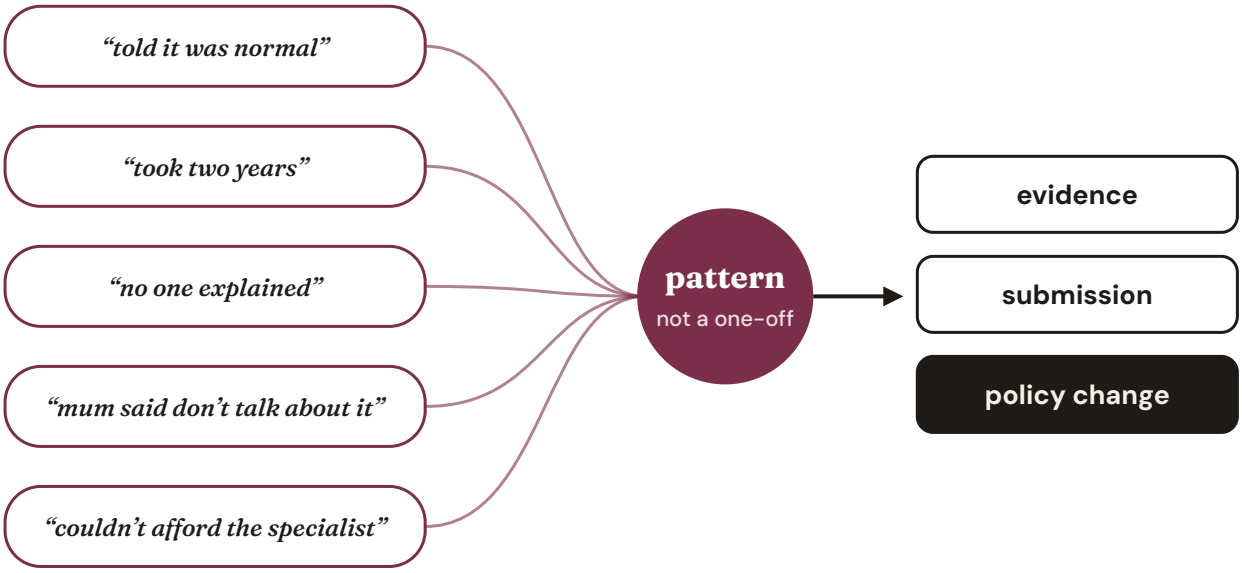
This is the edition our current programs grew out of. Young people kept telling us versions of the same story, and we realised self-advocacy alone asks each person to fight the same fight, one appointment at a time. Edition 04 was our first attempt to connect personal health agency with collective voice. It was the foundation for Aletheia's youth consultation, roundtables, Youth Executive Council and research work.

UNDERSTAND

01 When it’s not just you

You tell a friend your period pain was brushed off. She says the same thing happened to her. Then her cousin. Then half your group chat.

At some point, it stops being bad luck. If lots of people have the same experience, something in the way things are set up is producing it. That’s what people mean by a system: the rules, habits, funding, training and beliefs that shape what happens to everyone, not just you.



Quotes are illustrative, not real people.

One story is easy to dismiss. A pattern is much harder to ignore.

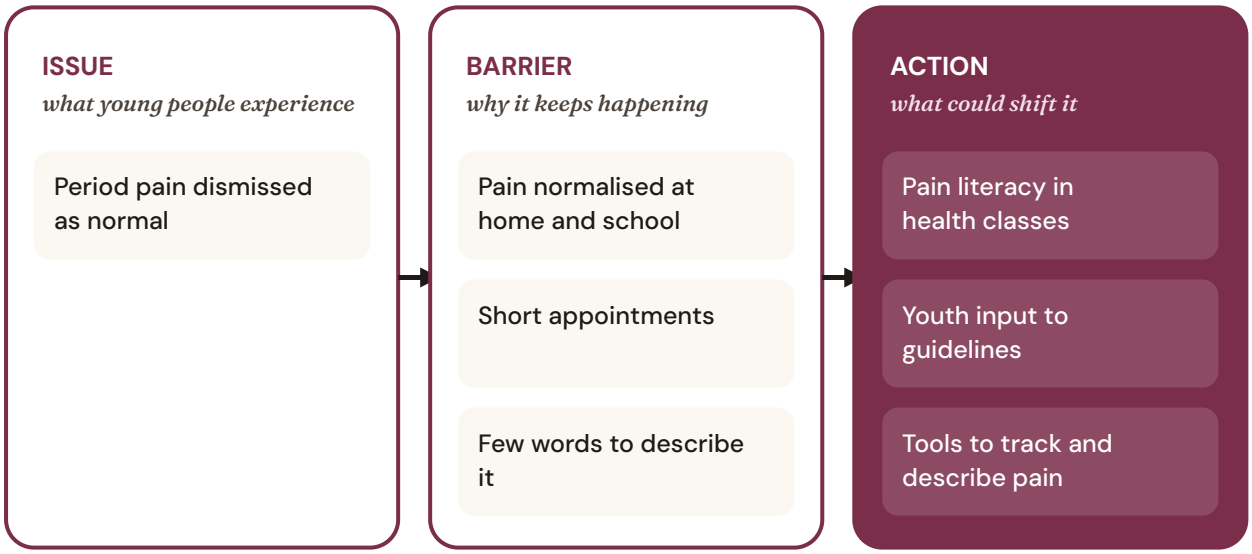
Evidence that it's a pattern

- For endometriosis, Australia's national guideline notes an average delay of 6 to 8 years from symptoms to diagnosis, and names symptom normalisation and stigma as key causes.
- In 2024 the Victorian Government ran an Inquiry into Women's Pain. Thousands of women and girls described pain being dismissed or not taken seriously.
- Young people, CALD communities, LGBTQIA+ people and people with disability often face extra barriers to being heard.

What a systems lens changes

- You stop asking only "What did I do wrong?" and start asking "Why does this keep happening?"
- Your experience becomes useful information, not just something that happened to you
- The solutions get bigger than one appointment: training, school curriculum, guidelines, access
- You realise you don't have to fix it alone

Issue → barrier → action



Every issue has barriers that keep it in place. Advocacy works best when it targets a specific barrier.

Health equity

WHAT IT IS

Everyone having a fair chance to be as healthy as possible, which sometimes means more support for people facing more barriers. It's different from treating everyone the same.

Lived experience

WHAT IT IS

Knowledge that comes from going through something yourself. In health, it's increasingly recognised as a form of expertise that sits alongside research and clinical knowledge.

NAVIGATE

02 Your own care still comes first

Seeing the bigger picture doesn’t mean putting your own health on hold. You can push for change and still need to get your own pain looked at on Tuesday.

Keep your record

Your tracker and notes protect your own care, and they’re the most accurate version of your story if you ever choose to share it.

Use the tools

Scripts, rights and pathways from **Edition 03** still apply. Systems thinking adds to them; it doesn’t replace them.

You don’t owe your story

You can advocate for change without ever sharing your personal health details. Your voice counts either way.

CONNECT

03 Sharing lived experience, safely

Stories change minds. But once a story is out, you can't take it back. Sharing well means protecting yourself, and anyone else in the story.

Before you share your story

- [ ] I'm sharing because I want to, not because I feel I have to
- [ ] I know who will see it, and where it will be published
- [ ] I've decided whether to use my name, first name only, or stay anonymous
- [ ] I've left out details that could identify other people (family, doctors, schools)
- [ ] I've left out details I might not want public in five years
- [ ] I know whether I can review or withdraw it before it's published
- [ ] I have someone to talk to afterwards if it brings things up

Tell the part that helps others

You don't need to share everything. Often the most useful part is one moment and what it changed:

- What happened
- How it affected your life
- What would have helped
- What you'd want decision-makers to change

Hearing other people's stories

If a friend shares something with you:

- Listen first, and believe them
- Don't repeat it without asking
- Share what helped you, if they want
- Point them to support if they're struggling
- If someone is at risk of harm, tell a trusted adult

Starting conversations at home and in community

In many cultures, health is discussed indirectly or not at all. Change often starts with one careful conversation. Try starting from something general ("I read that lots of women have endometriosis and don't know it") rather than personal, and choose a person who's likely to listen, like an aunt or older cousin, not the whole family at dinner.

AMPLIFY

04 Where young voices can count

Decisions about health are made in schools, clinics, hospitals, councils and parliaments. More of them are open to young people than you might think.

WHERE	HOW YOUNG PEOPLE TAKE PART	START WITH
Your school	Student voice on health classes, period products, wellbeing policy	Your SRC, or a teacher who'll champion it. VicSRC supports student voice in Victoria.
Health services	Feedback and complaints are counted and reviewed. Many services run youth advisory groups	Feedback forms, or a service's youth or consumer advisory group
Hospitals	Youth advisory councils advise on patient experience	For example, the Royal Children's Hospital's Youth @ the Kids, for ages 12–25
Councils	Youth councils and consultations on local services	Your local council's youth services team
Governments	Inquiries and consultations take written submissions, often from anyone	Watch for open consultations; a short submission from lived experience counts
Public conversation	Opinion pieces, blogs, podcasts, social content	Youth-led platforms that support new writers

Writing to someone who can change something

1

Say who you are and why you care

One or two lines. “I’m a Year 10 student in Melbourne who has had period pain dismissed.”

2

Describe the problem, and show it’s bigger than you

One short example, and one piece of evidence that it’s common.

3

Ask for one specific thing

“Include period pain and when to see a GP in the Year 8 health curriculum.” Specific asks get specific answers.

4

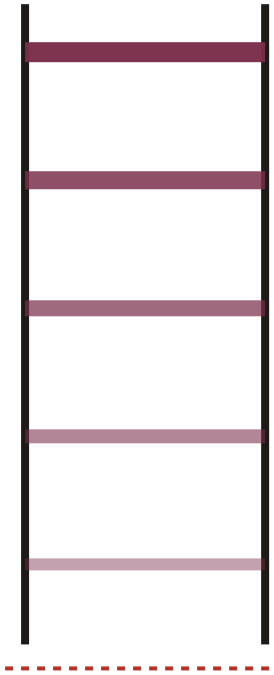
Offer to help

Offer to share a youth perspective, meet, or help test a resource. Then follow up in two to three weeks.

CHANGE

05 Real participation, not tokenism

Being invited in is a start. What matters is whether young people actually influence what happens.



5. Leading
Young people set the agenda and run it.

4. Co-designing
Young people shape the thing with decision-makers.

3. Involved
Young people sit on advisory groups and panels.

2. Consulted
Young people are asked, and told what changed.

1. Informed
Decisions are explained to young people.

Below the ladder: tokenism, present but with no real influence.

Adapted from well-known models of youth participation. Higher isn't always better for every decision, but young people should always know how their input was used.

Signs it's genuine

- You're told what the decision is and what can still change
- You get information in plain language, in time to prepare
- You're told afterwards what was done with your input
- Young people from different backgrounds are involved, not just one
- It's safe, supported and, where possible, paid or recognised

Questions to ask when you're invited

- What decision will this feed into?
- Who makes the final call?
- How will you tell us what changed?
- Who else is being asked?
- What support is there if topics are personal?

MAYA, THREE YEARS ON

From her story to a submission

After her referral, Maya gets answers, but it took years. When she mentions it in class, three other students say something similar happened to them.

With her SRC and a teacher's support, she runs a short anonymous survey about period pain and school. She doesn't collect names or health details, explains how the answers will be used, and gets the school's approval first.

Forty students respond. Most say they've missed class because of period pain, and many say they didn't know when pain was worth seeing a GP about. The SRC turns this into a two-page summary and a short submission when a youth consultation on health education opens.

Maya and these figures are fictional, used to show how the process works.

REFLECT

Your first step

1. What's one experience you've heard more than once from people your age?
2. What barrier keeps it happening?
3. Who has the power to change that barrier?
4. What's one small thing you could do this month?

WHERE THIS IDEA WENT NEXT

From collective voice to the Aletheia you see today

Edition 04 recognised that young people's experiences could shape systems. Our current programs are how we put that into practice, and the current Voice Pack is where it all comes together.

Youth Consultation
Young people's input into real decisions

Youth Roundtables
Young people and decision-makers in one room

Youth Executive Council
Youth leadership inside Aletheia

Youth Research
Lived experience as evidence

The current Voice Pack
Heard. Understood. Me. (April 2026)

Health education, not medical advice. This pack explains general health information so you can understand your body and talk about it. It cannot diagnose you. If you're worried about your health, speak to a doctor, nurse or other health professional. **In an emergency, call 000.**

Emergency · 000
If you or someone else is in danger or needs urgent medical help.

Kids Helpline · 1800 55 1800
Free, 24/7 phone and webchat, ages 5–25.

Lifeline · 13 11 14
24/7 crisis support. Text 0477 13 11 14.

headspace · headspace.org.au
Free or low-cost support, ages 12–25.

▶ **Sources and fact-checking (6)**

Written and designed by The Aletheia Project resource development team. Scenarios are fictional. We acknowledge the Wurundjeri Woi-wurrung people of the Kulin Nation, where Aletheia was founded. Sovereignty was never ceded.